

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN TUNISIA

Complete Community Opposition How-To

This guide is built around Tunisia's distinctive lever — an organised community that occupies the infrastructure, takes to the streets, and forces the state and the companies to the table — backed by a powerful trade union and a tradition of civic courage, and it names the tools you'll meet (the sit-in and occupation, the mass protest, the UGTT, the negotiated agreement, the courts) in plain words the first time. A note on danger: Tunisia's civic space has narrowed since 2021, and protests have been met with force, so protect people throughout.

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

In 2017, in the marginalised southern governorate of **Tataouine**, where nearly a third of people had no work, a movement of mostly young men did something the powerful never expected: they walked out into the desert, occupied the **El Kamour** pumping station that carries about half of Tunisia's crude oil, and **shut the valve**. They organised themselves without leaders a government could arrest or buy — a flat coordination committee of about ten, representing the towns of the governorate — camped in the sand through the heat, and refused to turn the oil back on until the state listened. In June 2017, brokered by the country's great trade union, the **UGTT**, they forced the government and the oil companies to sign an agreement: **fifteen hundred jobs** for the region, thousands more state jobs over three years, and a **development fund of eighty million dinars a year** for Tataouine. A poor, forgotten region had reached into the pipeline that fed the capital and made the state come to the table.

The young people of Tataouine who shut the valve at El Kamour built a model worth studying: a just claim, a flat and unbreakable structure — a committee of about ten, chosen so the authorities could not decapitate the movement by arresting or buying one leader — and a hard point of leverage in their grip on the infrastructure, sustained by a sit-in in the sand and mass protest. Behind that pressure stood real tools. The **UGTT** — the powerful trade union — can organise, broker, and protect, as it brokered the El Kamour agreement. A **negotiated agreement** can lock in jobs, funds, or protections in an enforceable form. And the **courts** are open, if imperfect. But these tools have grave limits, and this guide states them plainly. El Kamour won **jobs and a fund, not an end to the drilling** — it was a fight to *share* the wealth, not to *stop* the extraction, and that is often the realistic prize. The agreement was **implemented slowly and incompletely**, and the region had to rise again and again to demand what it had been promised. The protests were met by the **army and the police**, and people were hurt and killed. The democratic opening that made such pressure work has, since **2021, narrowed**, so the civic space a community relies on cannot be taken for granted. And beneath it all lies an unresolved wound: the marginalised interior and south have for generations sent their phosphate, their oil, and their labour to a coast that returned little. So enter such a fight understanding it is one battle in a long war over how a country shares what it takes from its poorest regions — and protect your people, because the space is narrowing and the response can be violent.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

A big project or a great injustice looks unstoppable, but the powerful depend on things a community can reach — the flow of the oil, the peace of the streets, the legitimacy of the state. An organised Tunisian

community can **occupy the infrastructure, take to the streets**, and — backed by the **UGTT** — force the state and the companies to a **negotiated agreement**. Every one of those is a lever you can grab — and the occupation of a hard point of leverage is the one that made the state come to the table at El Kamour. **Find the one closest to your hand and pull — safely.**

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Before you spend a year on this, work out your real situation:

- **If you hold a hard point of leverage — infrastructure the powerful depend on — occupying it can force them to the table**, as El Kamour did with the oil.
- **If your claim is just and widely felt, mass protest and the UGTT can carry it** — jobs, a fund, a facility closed, a commons reclaimed.
- **If the realistic prize is a fair share rather than a stop, aim for it honestly** — and keep pressing for the promises to be kept.
- **If the space has narrowed and the response can be violent, protect your people above all** — organise safely, without arrestable leaders, and weigh every risk.

Read the whole guide once before you move. Two habits run through it: **organise without arrestable leaders, hold a point of leverage, and force the state to the table** — the El Kamour template — and **protect your people and keep pressing for the promises**, because the space is narrowing, the response can be violent, and the agreements are kept only slowly. That's how El Kamour won — and had to keep winning.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

To break the chain you have to see it — who decides, how a project moves, and who's watching.

Who Actually Decides

The **government** and the **companies** hold the decisions over resources, projects, and development — but they depend on the **flow of the infrastructure** and the **peace of the streets**, which a community can affect. The **UGTT** — the trade union — is a powerful national actor that can organise, broker, and protect. A **negotiated agreement** is where such fights are often settled. The **courts** review decisions, imperfectly. And since 2021, the **security forces** and a more centralised state constrain the space. Know which point of leverage you can reach — and reach it safely.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

The infrastructure. The project or the state depends on infrastructure — a pipeline, a station, a road. *Your opening — the decisive one:* a **disciplined occupation or sit-in** at a hard point of leverage forces the powerful to the table.

The streets and the union. *Your opening:* **mass protest** and the **UGTT's** weight build the pressure and the protection.

The agreement. *Your opening:* a **negotiated agreement** locks in jobs, a fund, a closure, or a protection — then must be enforced.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Dig up three things. **Who's behind it and what they depend on** — the companies and the state, and the infrastructure and legitimacy they need. **What just claim you hold** — a fair share, a poisoned facility, a stolen commons: the claim that rallies the region and the nation. **What leverage you can reach safely** — the hard point that makes the powerful negotiate.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Each is an ally or an arena. The **UGTT** organises, brokers, and protects. The **courts** review decisions. The **press** carries the cause. And Tunisia's **organised communities, coordination committees, the trade union, and a tradition of civic courage** are the forces that reach furthest — the movement that shut the valve at El Kamour. Since 2021, watch the narrowing space and the security response.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Size up the odds honestly. These are rough patterns, not promises. What most moves them: whether you hold a hard point of leverage, whether your claim is just and widely felt, whether the UGTT joins, and how the state responds.

What you do	Roughly works	How long	Cost/Risk	What "works" means
Just gather documents	5–10%	weeks	low	The base for everything else
Mass protest	20–45%	weeks–months	mod risk	Pressure; the nation's attention
Occupy a hard point of leverage	35–60%	weeks–months	high risk	The state forced to the table (El Kamour)
UGTT backing / brokering	30–55%	weeks–months	mod	Organisation, weight, protection, a broker
Negotiated agreement	35–60%	months	mod	Jobs, a fund, a closure, a protection
Court challenge	20–45%	months–yr	mod	A decision reviewed
Enforcing a won agreement	25–50%	years	mod	The promise actually delivered
Everything together (leverage, just claim, UGTT)	40–65%	months–yr	high	The state to the table; a share or a stop
Everything together (narrowed space, violent response)	20–45%	months–yr	high	Partial; slow; dangerous

The lever that moves the needle most is **occupying a hard point of leverage**, backed by a **just claim, a flat unbreakable structure, and the UGTT**. El Kamour shows the ceiling (a forgotten region forcing the state to the table) and the honest floor (jobs and a fund not an end to the drilling, implemented slowly, met with force, in a narrowing space). So aim for a share forced, a facility closed, a commons reclaimed, or a project stopped — and protect your people.

*On cost and risk: organising and protesting cost little money, but the **risk is high** — the response can be violent, and the space has narrowed since 2021. The great strengths are a flat, unbreakable structure (no leader to arrest or buy), a hard point of leverage, and the UGTT's protection — and the great requirements are safety and the persistence to enforce a won agreement over years.*

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Being against "the project" is weak. Being specific — this leverage point, this just claim, this broken promise — is strong. Answer five questions in writing.

1. What is it, and who's behind it — and what do they depend on? Name the project or injustice, the companies and the state, and the **infrastructure and legitimacy** they need.

2. What just claim do you hold? A fair share of the region's wealth, a facility that poisons your land, a commons taken from you. **A just, widely felt claim is your foundation** — it rallied Tataouine and the nation.

3. What hard point of leverage can you reach — safely? A pipeline, a station, a road, the streets. El Kamour held the oil the capital depended on.

4. What stage is it at, and what's the next opening? A protest wave, a negotiation, an agreement to be signed — or a promise to be enforced. These openings are time-bound.

5. Can you organise safely, and will the UGTT join? A flat coordination committee (no arrestable leaders), and the trade union's weight and protection. El Kamour's structure was its shield.

What this looks like in real life. A region sees its oil, phosphate, or land taken while it stays poor and unemployed, or a facility poisons it. The five questions yield: companies and a state that depend on infrastructure and peace; a just claim (a fair share, a poisoned land); a hard point of leverage; an opening to press; and a flat structure with the UGTT. That's the El Kamour pattern — organise safely, hold a point of leverage, and force the state to the table.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION

The difference between a community that can fight and one that can't is proof — and a just, documented claim. Build it in three layers.

Layer one: the just claim. Document the **injustice** — the region's wealth taken and little returned, the jobs denied, the facility that poisons, the commons stolen — with the figures and the history. This is the claim that rallies the region and the nation, as Tataouine's neglect did.

Layer two: the paper trail and the harm. Get what documents you can — the contracts, the permits, the promises made and broken — and gather dated photographs and testimony of the harm and the neglect. Where an agreement was won and not kept, document the broken promise.

Layer three: the map of leverage and claim. Identify and map the **hard point of leverage** and the just claim, so you know where the powerful can be reached and what will rally the people. Walking into a negotiation — with a just claim, a hard point of leverage, and the UGTT — is what makes the state come to the table.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

- **The just claim** — the region's wealth taken, the jobs denied, the poisoning, the stolen commons, with figures and history.
- **The contracts, permits, and promises** — made and broken — from the state and the companies where obtainable.

- **The harm and the neglect** — dated photographs and testimony.
- **The leverage-and-claim map** — the hard point of leverage and the just claim.
- **A safe organising structure** — a flat coordination committee, documented for the movement, not for the authorities.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Documents give you a case; an organised, unbreakable community with the UGTT gives you power — the El Kamour model. Build in four moves, safely.

Organise without arrestable leaders — the decisive structure. El Kamour's shield was a **flat coordination committee** of about ten, so the authorities could not decapitate the movement by arresting or buying one leader. Build that flat, unbreakable structure — it is your protection and your strength, especially in a narrowing space.

Root it in a just, widely felt claim. The movement drew its force and its wide support from a just claim — a region's wealth taken, its young left jobless. Root your fight in that claim, so the region and the nation stand with you.

Bring in the UGTT. The trade union organised, brokered, and protected at El Kamour, and brokered the agreement. Reach the **UGTT** early — its weight, its structure, and its protection are among the most powerful things a Tunisian movement can have.

Plan for leverage, endurance, and safety. Identify a hard point of leverage, and plan a **disciplined, largely peaceful** occupation or protest — with legal and union advice, and above all with **people's safety first**, because the response can be violent. Build for the long endurance to hold the line and to enforce any agreement won, because promises here are kept only slowly.

STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES, LEVERAGE & THE NEGOTIATED AGREEMENT

Tunisia's sharpest lever is organised leverage that forces the state to the table, backed by the UGTT, the negotiated agreement, and the courts.

The Occupation — the Hard Point of Leverage

The route that won at El Kamour: a **disciplined occupation or sit-in** at a **hard point of leverage** — the infrastructure the powerful depend on — that forces the state and the companies to negotiate. Choose the point of leverage carefully, organise without arrestable leaders, keep it disciplined and largely peaceful, and **protect your people**, because this is powerful but high-risk, and the response can be violent.

The UGTT and the Negotiated Agreement

The **UGTT** can organise, broker, and protect, and can broker the **negotiated agreement** — jobs, a development fund, a facility closed, a protection — that settles such fights. Reach the union, and aim the leverage at a concrete, enforceable agreement.

The Courts and Enforcement

The **courts** are open, if imperfect, for challenging an unlawful permit or decision. And crucially, a **won agreement must be enforced**: El Kamour's promises came slowly and incompletely, and the region had to rise again to demand them. Plan to hold the state to its word.

The Honest Limits

Straight talk: occupation, the UGTT, and the agreement are powerful, but the realistic prize is often a **fair share rather than a stop**, the agreements are kept slowly, the response can be **violent**, and the civic space has **narrowed since 2021**. So use the strong tools — the leverage, the UGTT, the agreement, the courts — protect your people, keep pressing for the promises, and count a share forced, a facility closed, a commons reclaimed, or a project stopped as wins.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

A stack of documents wins nothing until you aim it.

A just claim becomes a national cause. Not "we are angry" but *"our region's oil feeds the capital while our young have no work — we demand our fair share,"* as Tataouine did.

Leverage becomes a summons. *"We hold the valve the capital depends on — the state must come to the table."*

A structure becomes a shield. *"We have no single leader to arrest or buy — we are a committee of the towns, and we cannot be decapitated."*

A broken promise becomes a renewed demand. *"You signed an agreement and did not keep it — we rise again to demand it."*

Match it to the venue: the just claim to the region and the nation; the leverage to the state and the companies; the structure to your movement; the broken promise to the state and the UGTT.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

In Tunisia, the nation's attention and the region's just claim are the levers — a forgotten region's stand can rouse the country, as El Kamour did. A press and the UGTT make the media front central, though the narrowing space demands care.

Lead with the injustice and the claim, not procedure. Not "the contract terms are unfair" but "our region's oil feeds the capital while our young sit jobless — and we have shut the valve until the state listens." Use your strongest material: the just claim and its figures, the human story, dated photographs, and the UGTT's backing.

Work several audiences at once — carefully. Local and national press rouse the region and the nation; the UGTT amplifies and protects; but in a narrowing space, weigh what exposure helps and what endangers people. Make it easy: captioned photos, accurate summaries, strong testimony.

Two hard rules. Accuracy above all — one exaggeration can discredit everything. And protect people — in a narrowing space with a violent-capable response, let the movement shape its story safely, and never expose individuals to danger.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Make them your own; keep them short, exact and calm; keep a copy of everything. In a narrowing space, take care with what you put in writing and who is named.

8A — Stating the just claim (to the state / companies).

Subject: Our region's fair share — [resource/project].

"We, the community of [region], demand [our fair share of the wealth / jobs / the closure of the poisoning facility / the return of our commons]: [the figures and the history]. [Contact.]"

8B — To the UGTT.

Subject: Request for the union's support — [region].

"Our region faces [the injustice], and we are organising to press our claim. We ask the UGTT to organise, broker, and stand with us, as at El Kamour. [Contact and evidence summary.]"

8C — Announcing a disciplined action (internal / public).

Subject: Our disciplined stand for [the claim].

"We, the coordination committee of [the towns], announce a disciplined, peaceful [sit-in / protest] for [the claim], organised without arrestable leaders. We call on all who share the claim to join, safely. [Contact.]"

8D — Demanding negotiation (to the state / companies).

Subject: Come to the table — [the claim].

"We hold [the leverage] and speak for [the region]. We demand that the state and the companies negotiate [the agreement] — jobs, a fund, a closure, a protection. [Contact.]"

8E — Enforcing a won agreement.

Subject: Keep the agreement you signed — [region].

"The agreement of [date] promised [jobs / the fund / the closure], and it has not been delivered. We, the community of [region], demand that it be kept, and we will press until it is. [Attach the agreement.]"

8F — To a lawyer (court challenge).

Subject: Possible challenge — [permit/decision].

"Our community faces [project/decision], which we believe unlawful: [specifics]. We've gathered [the evidence]. We ask your advice on challenging it. [Contact and evidence summary.]"

8G — Letter to the press.

Subject: [Region] rises for its fair share against [project].

"Our region's [oil/phosphate/land] feeds [the capital] while our young have no work. We can provide the figures, the history, photographs, and interviews. [Contact.]"

8H — Rallying the region.

Subject: Our wealth, our region — here's how we make them listen.

"[The injustice] has gone on too long. At El Kamour, an organised, leaderless community held the valve and forced the state to the table — jobs and a fund for the region. If we organise safely, hold our claim, and stand together, we can too. Please join us. [Contact.]"

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

If you must move fast and lean — and safely — do these six things, in order:

1. **State the just claim, with figures and history (8A).** That's your foundation and your rallying cry.
2. **Organise a flat coordination committee — no arrestable leaders (8C).** That's your shield.
3. **Bring in the UGTT for weight and protection (8B).**
4. **Identify a hard point of leverage you can reach safely — and plan a disciplined, peaceful action.**
5. **Demand negotiation for a concrete agreement (8D).**
6. **Enforce any agreement won (8E) — and protect your people throughout.**

Even lean, those six organise safely, hold a point of leverage, and force the state to the table — the El Kamour template.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Tunisia's tools are real, but the space has narrowed since 2021 and the response can be violent, so you must plan for it carefully.

When the space is narrowing. Organise without arrestable leaders, lean on the UGTT's protection, and weigh every action against the risk — the flat structure that shielded El Kamour matters more than ever.

When the response is violent. Keep actions disciplined and peaceful, plan for safety with legal and union advice, and never expose individuals to needless danger.

When the realistic prize is a share, not a stop. Aim for the fair share, the fund, the closure, or the protection you can win — and keep pressing, because these are real gains in a long war.

When the agreement isn't kept. El Kamour's promises came slowly. Stay organised, and rise again to enforce what you were promised.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO'S CAPTURED

Tunisia has real, documented problems with the capture of resources and the neglect of the interior and south, so this matters.

How to spot it. A region's wealth taken while it stays poor; contracts on opaque terms; promises signed and broken; benefits to the connected and the coast while the interior bears the cost.

Who's supposed to guard against it. Audit and anti-corruption bodies examine public money and conduct, imperfectly. The **courts** can review a tainted decision. The **UGTT** and civil society press for fairness. And

Tunisia's **press and civic organisations** have exposed captured deals — though the narrowing space constrains them.

How to fight it safely. Document precisely and factually — the wealth taken, who benefits, the broken promises — and keep clear the line between what you can prove and what you suspect. Route serious evidence to the audit and anti-corruption bodies, the courts, the UGTT, and trusted journalists rather than making accusations you can't back. Protect those exposed, and pair the exposure with the organised claim.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

Don't run these steps one after another — run them together, safely. The just claim rallies the region; the flat structure shields it; the UGTT organises and protects; the leverage forces the table; the agreement locks in the gain; the press rouses the nation; and enforcement holds the state to its word. Together they multiply. One at a time, they stall — and protect your people throughout.

Early on (weeks 1–8): state and document the just claim; organise a flat coordination committee; bring in the UGTT; identify a hard point of leverage you can reach safely.

In the thick of it (weeks–months): mount a disciplined action at the point of leverage; demand negotiation; rouse the nation carefully; keep people safe.

The long haul (months–years): win and then enforce the agreement; rise again if the promises are not kept; hold the line for a share forced, a facility closed, a commons reclaimed, or a project stopped — protecting your people throughout.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Forcing the powerful to the table in Tunisia can be done — a poor, forgotten region walked into the desert, shut the valve on half the nation's oil, and made the state come to negotiate jobs and a fund. Hold both truths. Tunisia's distinctive power is real: in the democracy Tunisians won in 2011, an organised community can occupy the infrastructure, take to the streets, and — backed by the UGTT and a tradition of civic courage — force the state and the companies to the table, to share the wealth, close a poisoning facility, or reclaim a commons. And the constraints are real: the realistic prize is often a fair share rather than a stop; the agreements are kept slowly; the response has been violent; and the civic space has narrowed since 2021.

Here's the discipline that wins. Root your fight in a just, widely felt claim — the region's wealth taken, its young left jobless — that rallies the region and the nation. Organise without arrestable leaders, in a flat coordination committee, because that structure is your shield, especially in a narrowing space. Bring in the UGTT for its weight, its brokering, and its protection. Identify a hard point of leverage you can reach, and plan a disciplined, largely peaceful occupation or protest — with people's safety first, because the response can be violent. Aim the leverage at a concrete, enforceable agreement, and keep pressing to enforce it, because the promises come slowly. Understand that this is one battle in a long war over how a country shares what it takes from its poorest regions, and protect your people above all. Count a share forced, a facility closed, a commons reclaimed, or a project stopped as wins. That's what El Kamour did — a just claim, a flat unbreakable structure, a hard point of leverage, and the UGTT together. So can you.